

Rork Harding's Auto Garage – Award-Winning Website Design Guide

1. Project overview

The **Rork Harding's Auto Garage** project in the GitHub repository currently uses **React Native (Expo + React Router)** to produce a cross-platform app that can be exported to the web. The existing code (app/index.tsx) defines a single landing page with:

- **Hero gallery:** a slider showing photos of the garage. It uses an **Animated view** and a timer to fade images in/out. Each slide includes a tagline and buttons to **call**, **WhatsApp** or **view location**. Contact buttons open the respective phone/WhatsApp links.
- **Services section:** an array of service objects displays icons (wrench, electrical bolt, shield, award) with a name and description. These cards are arranged in a grid.
- **About section:** describes the business with some body text and a “Read more” link. A mechanical background graphic appears behind the text.
- **Statistics:** counters (years experience, happy clients, projects done, rating) emphasise credibility.
- **Contact cards:** three boxes encourage visitors to call, message on WhatsApp or open Google Maps. Each box has an icon and label.

The page uses a dark, metallic colour palette defined in constants/colors.ts and employs gradients and icons from **Lucide**. Animations rely on **Animated** and **useRef** to fade or slide elements.

2. Research: What makes automotive sites award-winning?

Essential design principles

A design guide from IceCube Digital summarises that a successful automotive website must be **responsive**, provide **clear navigation**, feature **high-quality visuals** and use **compelling calls-to-action** [918858990400688†L338-L390]. The article notes that modern visitors use mobile devices, so a mobile-first approach is crucial; key buttons and text must remain visible and readable on small screens [918858990400688†L344-L349]. Clear navigation layouts help visitors find services or vehicle details quickly [918858990400688†L354-L364], while professional images, videos and graphics grab attention and showcase vehicles/services effectively [918858990400688†L366-L374]. Strategically placed CTAs encourage actions such as booking a service, requesting a quote or signing up for a newsletter [918858990400688†L380-L389].

A review of top auto-repair websites by CyberOptik emphasises similar points. It praises sites with **intuitive navigation and logically structured menus** that let visitors find services, pricing or contact details quickly [571698357423879†L250-L267]. The best sites prominently display **call-to-action buttons** to nudge users toward booking or requesting quotes [571698357423879†L250-L257]. Consistently strong designs mix modern colour schemes

(e.g., red/black or blue/white), high-resolution images and dynamic graphics to project professionalism 【571698357423879†L286-L304】 . Some sites incorporate slideshows of before-and-after repairs 【571698357423879†L326-L337】 or video backgrounds to capture attention. Testimonials and client reviews build trust and credibility 【571698357423879†L354-L363】 .

Micro-interactions and delight

Micro-interactions—small responses to user actions—enhance engagement. An article from Jacob Tyler describes them as interactions triggered by user actions, governed by rules, giving feedback (e.g., colour change) and possibly looping 【577439484861475†L24-L41】 . They smooth navigation, reassure users that actions succeeded and make the interface feel human 【577439484861475†L53-L69】 . Best practices include keeping micro-interactions simple and consistent, providing quick feedback and matching the context (e.g., a spinner after pressing “Submit”) 【577439484861475†L79-L95】 . Too many micro-interactions or laggy animations can frustrate users 【577439484861475†L96-L113】 .

Effective call-to-action (CTA) design

The Tubik Studio guide on CTA buttons stresses that **contrast** is vital; buttons should stand out from background colours so they are easy to spot 【295369536183909†L376-L380】 . CTA text must be short and **imperative** (“Book now”, “Get a quote”), using as few words as possible to drive action 【295369536183909†L384-L392】 . Large sizes and bright colours catch attention, but **placement** should align with the user flow—users should see a CTA after reading information about the service 【295369536183909†L398-L412】 . White space around buttons emphasises them; reducing space between a CTA and supportive text (e.g., service description) links the elements 【295369536183909†L416-L432】 .

White space and visual balance

White space (negative space) refers to the unmarked areas between elements. CleverLight’s article notes that white space enhances readability and comprehension, prevents information overload and balances complex elements 【866686244906138†L51-L59】 . It can strategically draw attention to important elements like CTAs or featured services 【866686244906138†L60-L62】 and conveys sophistication 【866686244906138†L63-L65】 . Designers should identify key elements and surround them with ample space, maintain consistent spacing across similar elements and use white space to group related content 【866686244906138†L69-L86】 .

3. Proposed aesthetic vision

3.1 Overall theme

- **Mood:** An auto-workshop theme should feel **industrial yet modern**—think polished metal, carbon fibre textures and subtle grease marks—but balanced with clean typography and generous white space to avoid looking grungy. The site should evoke trust, craftsmanship and performance.
- **Colour palette:** Retain a dark base (charcoal or matte black) but replace flat shades with **metallic gradients** and subtle textures. Accent colours could be:

- **Crimson red (#D62828)** or **bright amber (#F4A261)** for CTA buttons, highlights and interactive states (red signals energy and urgency; amber suggests warmth and friendliness). Use high contrast so buttons stand out [295369536183909†L376-L380] .
- **Steel blue (#1F4E79)** or **gunmetal gray (#2C3E50)** for backgrounds and cards, to evoke machinery and professionalism.
- **Silver/light gray (#E2E8F0)** for text on dark backgrounds and icons.
- **Typography:** Use a bold, modern sans-serif for headings (e.g., *Poppins*, *Montserrat* or *Oswald*) and a clean, easy-reading sans-serif (e.g., *Roboto*, *Inter* or *Nunito Sans*) for body text. Maintain generous line spacing and choose weights that contrast (bold headings vs. regular body) to create hierarchy. Avoid decorative fonts that might hinder readability.
- **Imagery and textures:** Employ **high-resolution photographs** of the workshop—mechanics at work, close-ups of engines or tools. Overlays such as dark gradients or blur can ensure text remains readable on top of photos. Incorporate subtle **gear-pattern graphics** or carbon-fibre textures as section backgrounds or separators to reinforce the mechanical theme without overwhelming the page.
- **Iconography:** Continue using **Lucide** icons but consider customizing them to match the chosen colour palette. Line-style icons with a secondary colour fill on hover can add personality. Use automotive-related icons (wrenches, engines, shields, speedometers) consistently across the site.

3.2 Layout and structure

The existing one-page structure works well. To elevate it, refine each section:

1. Hero section

- **Full-width background slider:** Replace static images with a high-quality **autoplay slider** or **Ken Burns effect** (slow zoom/pan) to showcase the workshop and completed projects. Use a semi-transparent dark overlay so the tagline and CTAs remain legible.
- **Animated headline:** Use a large headline (e.g., “Trusted Auto Repairs & Service”) with a light animation—letters sliding in or fading up. Beneath, a short subheading emphasises experience (“15+ years keeping you on the road”).
- **Primary CTA buttons:** Include two prominent buttons (e.g., *Book Service* and *Call Now*). Buttons should be large, use contrasting colours [295369536183909†L376-L380] , have rounded corners and subtle shadows. On hover, apply a slight scale-up or colour change (micro-interaction) to encourage clicks. A third, secondary button (e.g., *WhatsApp*) can be styled as an outline.
- **Down arrow indicator:** A bouncing arrow invites users to scroll, hinting at additional content.

2. Services section

- **Grid layout:** Display services in a **responsive grid** (two columns on desktop; one column on mobile). Each card should feature an icon, a concise title and a short description. Use a **card hover effect**: on hover, the icon can animate (e.g.,

rotate slightly) and the card can lift with a shadow (micro-interaction) [\[577439484861475†L53-L69\]](#) .

- **Background and separators:** Distinguish this section with a darker shade or a subtle diagonal background pattern resembling tyre tracks. Use white space around each card [\[866686244906138†L69-L86\]](#) to avoid clutter.
- **Learn more links:** For each service, optionally include a small link or arrow that could expand details in a modal instead of navigating away (maintains single-page flow).

3. About section

- **Split layout:** On larger screens, divide the section into two columns: a photo of the workshop or team on one side and text on the other. Use a dark translucent overlay behind text to ensure readability. On mobile, stack the image above the text.
- **Content:** Briefly tell the story (mission, values, commitment to quality) and emphasise certifications or partnerships. Use bullet points or icons to highlight key facts.
- **Secondary CTA:** End the section with a button inviting users to *Learn More* or *View Portfolio*.

4. Statistics (credibility)

- Display the four metrics in **individual counters** with icons. As the section scrolls into view, animate the numbers counting up from zero to their final values (a micro-interaction). Use cards or circles with metallic gradients and subtle drop shadows to give a premium feel. Arrange them horizontally on desktop and in two rows on mobile.

5. Gallery / Testimonials (optional)

While testimonials aren't in the original site, they dramatically enhance credibility. If adding them doesn't compromise development time, consider a **carousel** of before-and-after photos or quotes from happy clients. Each slide could include a photo, a short testimonial, the customer's name and rating. If adding testimonials is not possible, incorporate at least a **portfolio gallery** with lightbox pop-ups; this satisfies curiosity without altering the existing navigation.

6. Contact & CTA section

- **Contact cards redesign:** Transform the call/WhatsApp/location boxes into **interactive cards** with gradient backgrounds and glowing outlines. Use icons that animate (e.g., phone shaking) on hover or tap. Provide a clear label ("Call Us", "WhatsApp Us", "Find Us") and subtext. Each card should link to the respective action (tel:, <https://wa.me>, or Google Maps). Use consistent spacing and group the cards together so users perceive them as related [\[866686244906138†L83-L86\]](#) .
- **Embedded map:** Include a small map view (e.g., using Google Maps or Mapbox) below the cards, pinned to the garage's location. Provide an interactive control to get directions.

- **Footer:** Use a darker background with your logo, quick navigation links (e.g., Home, Services, About, Contact), social media icons and a copyright line. Add a subtle top border or gradient to separate it from the content.

3.3 Interaction & motion

- **Scroll-based animations:** Use react-native-reanimated or CSS (on web) to animate elements as they enter the viewport—cards can slide up, fade in or zoom slightly. Avoid heavy animations that cause lag [\[577439484861475†L96-L113\]](#) .
- **Parallax effects:** For section backgrounds, apply gentle parallax so background images move slower than foreground content, creating depth. This can be achieved with scroll listeners and Animated values.
- **Micro-interactions:** Implement subtle interactions on buttons and icons—colour changes, scaling or icon animation on hover/click. Keep them simple and consistent [\[577439484861475†L79-L95\]](#) .
- **Loader / progress indicators:** For actions like sending a WhatsApp message or loading a gallery image, show quick feedback (e.g., spinner) so users know the action is processing [\[577439484861475†L79-L95\]](#) .
- **Counter animations:** The statistics section can use Animated.timing to count up numbers smoothly over a second or two when the section becomes visible.

4. Implementation suggestions using Gemini CLI & React Native

1. **Update the colour palette:** Modify constants/colors.ts to reflect the new palette. Define variables like primary, accent, backgroundDark, backgroundLight, textPrimary and textSecondary. Replace usages in index.tsx accordingly.
2. **Apply global styling:** Create a common style or a Tailwind-like utility (e.g., NativeWind or styled-components) to enforce consistent margins, padding and font sizes. Use the Spacing constants to maintain uniform white space [\[866686244906138†L69-L86\]](#) .
3. **Hero slider enhancement:** In index.tsx, replace the current static ImageBackground sequence with a FlatList of images and apply a react-native-snap-carousel or your own Animated scroll that auto-plays. Overlay the headline and CTA buttons using absolute positioning and use LinearGradient to darken the lower part of the images for text contrast.
4. **Service card component:** Extract each service into its own React component with props for title, description and icon. Use Pressable to add hover/touch feedback—scale up slightly when pressed and revert on release. Use Moti or Reanimated for entrance animations.
5. **Animated statistics:** Create a Counter component that accepts start, end and duration props. Use Animated.Value or react-native-reanimated's useSharedValue to animate numbers when the component appears (using useEffect or useAnimatedScrollHandler).

6. **Contact cards redesign:** Use react-native-linear-gradient for backgrounds and wrap Pressable around each card. Add icons from Lucide with accent colours. For the map, integrate expo-location and expo-maps or embed a WebView with a Google Maps iframe on web.
7. **Accessibility considerations:** Ensure sufficient colour contrast (WCAG AA), add aria-labels to interactive elements and provide alt text for images. Make buttons at least **44×44 px** for touch targets and include keyboard focus states.
8. **Testing and iteration:** Use the **Gemini CLI** to generate components or code snippets and test them locally with expo start/bun run start-web. Perform A/B testing on button colours or placements using react-native-testing-library. Use analytics (e.g., Google Analytics or Mixpanel) to track clicks on CTAs and refine design accordingly **[295369536183909†L446-L463]** .
9. **Deployment:** After implementing and testing, push the changes to the GitHub repository (rork-hardings-auto-garage-website) via your usual Git workflow. Connect the repository to Netlify for web deployment. Use Netlify's build command (e.g., bun run build or expo build:web) and configure environment variables if necessary. Monitor performance and iterate.

5. Final thoughts

Transforming Rork Harding's Auto Garage website into an award-winning experience involves more than applying a new coat of paint; it requires **careful attention to user experience, visual storytelling and performance**. By embracing a polished industrial aesthetic, refining the layout with generous white space, using high-quality photography and dynamic animations, and adhering to UI/UX best practices (responsive design **[918858990400688†L344-L349]** , clear navigation **[918858990400688†L354-L364]** , compelling CTAs **[571698357423879†L250-L257]** and micro-interactions **[577439484861475†L79-L95]**), the site can exude professionalism and trust. Implement the recommendations incrementally, test with real users and let data guide refinements. The result should be a **visually stunning yet functional** website that reflects the workshop's craftsmanship and convinces visitors to choose Rork Harding's Auto Garage for their automotive needs.